

Shoresh

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The events described are true fiction. Any similarity to actual persons, living or dead, or to actual events is purely coincidental.

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Prologue

From Hebrew:

Shoresh / שורש

- Literally: root—the part of a plant, generally underground, that anchors and supports the plant body, absorbs and stores water and nutrients, and in some plants is able to perform vegetative reproduction
- by extension, root: a source or basis
- by extension, in linguistics: root of a Semitic word
- by extension, in mathematics: root as in square root

Ilan / אילן

- Noun: tree.
- Proper noun: a male given name.

Nitzanah / ניצנה

- Noun: a blossom; flower bud.
- Proper noun: a female given name.

Start

“HOW MANY KIDS WOULD YOU HAVE HAD? I mean, if it were not for...”

Her voice slowly fades out, her face shying away the same way she does every time the topic of her mother is approached. So many times, so many years, and it still pains me to see how she gets the guilty blow-back from herself every time she does it, and yet she cannot avoid repeating it.

I say, “Hey Ladybug, don’t get blue—it does not hurt like before.” It’s a lie, it still hurts. And she senses it somehow.

I reach out for her, bringing her to a hug as she shyly and yet dramatically trudges into the living room from the apartment’s entrance. I sniff her hair for a while and notice: smoke. I ask, “Were you smoking?”

She takes some distance, opens her mouth demonstratively and exhales in my direction: negative for smoke.

“It was Justyna,” she says. “We gathered in the park, she’s got the confirmation of a position. She will start right after finishing training, in some months. She was musing that, with her and Thomas having confirmed positions, they can start to make plans for a baby.”

“So, *this* is where this kid-number-story comes from,” I comment. “Now tell me: how will Justyna have a baby and smoke? Or...”

“... she will have to stop when she decides to get pregnant, so she wants to smoke now while she can,” she complements my line of thought. She is good at doing that—just like her mother. I usually hate when people try to predict what others are about to say, but only because most of the time people get it wrong.

Nitzanah never does it.

I invite her, with gestures, to sit down. She does it, drops her backpack near the couch. She still dresses like a kid, even though she’s a woman old enough to muse about having kids in earnest. I feel glad that I enjoyed her years as a kid as fully as I could.

I decide that it starts now.

“Nitzy...” She understands by the undertone that her attention is required.

“Yes?”

“Did Justyna comment on pre-natal precautions, like genetic screening?” I ask.

“No... is that not only recommended for persons at risk of some problem?”

I answer, “Mostly, yes—and I do not know if she or her partner—Thomas?—are at risk... but perhaps it is important that you know about us.”

Her whole posture and attitude changes, now she’s straightened up and looking at me very earnestly. She’s waiting for the continuation. I abide.

“For one, I do not believe I told you before, but I am a thalassemia carrier. It is a genetic condition that can cause anemia of diverse degrees, depending on how many genes are affected. Now, you do not

have anemia, and probably do not have any gene affected, but there are several conditions that may run silent and still be a problem for the children. And there are things about your mother's side you do not know, but should, before you have children."

She looks at me for a while. After some reflection that I recognize from oh so many sweet moments, she declares, "You are preparing me to get away from you. To be alone. Stop."

I laugh out loud and reply "Of course I am not! Do not be so dramatic. Just like your mother, aren't you? Just look at you: a fully grown woman. If Justyna can start having kids anytime, so do you. And if you do, why not check things beforehand?"

She smiles at me in a warm way. It breaks my heart not being capable of telling the truth as it is and hiding behind a lab result.

Bloodwork

Funny, actually funny. A different kind of clinic, not like the routine visits to the immunologist. The nurses look different, laugh differently, behave differently— they just *are* different.

Dad waits reading at the reception, the whole procedure is rather simple. I imagined that they would take half of my blood away, like, a big bottle or something, but it does not look like much. I guess that even the immunologist claimed more blood from me than what these guys are doing.

I feel positive the whole time and it is just when I meet dad again, when he raises his eyes from the magazine he's reading, that I notice something. Again, like he is saying goodbye to me.

I try to find a way to him, but I cannot. I want to believe that none of us is responsible, but I have no foundation for that.

Result

I try to behave normally but I feel that she notices that something is not quite alright. I try to divert her attention, I falsely ask, “Hey, Ladybug, why are you so nervous? Remember, this is more about possible kids than it is about you...” and I instantly regret it and want to take it back.

She looks at me with an inquiring look and gives me no answer—she is not nervous at all. I am.

I will regret these last moments of innocence forever, because I am tarnishing them.

THE NEWS HITS LIKE A STONE FALLING ON STAMPED EARTH. The physician looks at me with the knowing look that I was expecting. Nitzanah silences at my side the way I expected, for long moments. The physician is friendly enough to give us time.

I do not dare to look at her. Like the coward that I am, I hide behind the armrests of my chair. Minutes, hours, days go by—the physician is understanding enough to have postponed all his other appointments.

She is clinging to me and I weep. A nurse comes in, the physician orders something. We are both brought to another room. I take the medication the physician ordered—she does it too. It will help, the nurse says.

AN ETERNITY GOES BY. I sleep through the afternoon, she apparently too. One might assume that a genetics clinic has preparedness for stressful revelations of all kind. The clinic's personnel orders a taxi, we are brought home. The driver follows us until the apartment's entrance and makes sure we get inside. A patient's taxi driver.

Now the most dreaded moment: to be alone with her.

Talk

He wants to hide but I won't let him. I block the narrow corridor that leads to the apartment's kitchen and rooms. I demand answers, I want them now, but he won't do it now. He says he will explain everything later.

He confirms that he knew it, all along. I spit out the truth, that he never told me, never hinted at anything. He replies that there would never be an ideal moment and my adulthood presented the best opportunity. I feel like I was a puppet being pulled by strings this whole time. I know that parents manage their kids and don't always tell everything, but this is too much.

He asks for time, to rest, to bring "order to his thoughts." What about my thoughts, my feelings? I am the victim here, I remind him. I see that it hurts and I feel a jolt of joy but also a sting of sadness. I give him the time he wants.

I hear him call in sick at work. He promises to have the whole following day free for talk.

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Explanations

I understand that she needs time. I have been bracing for this moment since I made the decision, nearly two decades ago. I always knew this moment would come. And I never imagined how unprepared I would feel when it finally came.

I feel physical pain in my body, a pain that comes from seeing her suffering, and from knowing that I am the reason of her suffering.

I approach her from behind, she is giving me her back, watching through the window and I know why. I touch her shoulders lightly, just to deliver her a tactile confirmation that I want to be with her.

I tell her, “Hey, there is a lot of things that I can explain to you. First, my reasons, of course. But also about the technical side. I would prefer that you get it from me than from some internet source.”

She stays silent for some moments. Then a reply, “Okay. Just give me some moments.”

And she goes to gather a paper notebook and a pencil. I take my usual seat at our small wooden kitchen table while she scribes vigorously one bullet point after the other. I feel proud of her.

I look at her and I wonder if the fact that she looks so little like her mother is why I love her so much. The straightness of the hair does

not match, the facial structure is different, probably a consequence of repeated rhinitis and sinusitis during childhood, even the height and body build differ. So many things can influence how bodies develop, what to say about minds?

She wakes me up from my daydream, asks, “So, what is my legal situation? In Germany?”

Straight to the point—that’s my girl. I tell her what I always knew and kept up-to-date, “German law consider all human beings worth of human dignity, independently of how they come into existence. The process by which you came to life is not allowed in Germany, but you had no part in it and cannot be blamed. If at all, I would be the criminal, if it were done here... but it was not, it was in China, and there, it is legal.”

“So, none of us is going to prison?”

I reassure her, “No, neither you, nor me. And the genetics clinic is now allowed to share the information with anyone else without your permission.”

She looks genuinely relieved. She asks, “Are you sure about that?”

I answer, “I was sure even before I started everything. I tend to think long-term, Ladybug.”

She gives me the first smile since the revelation, since the result.

“Okay, next question. But before the question: I understand that you needed to wait until I was... old enough to understand the situation. But then the question: why to mention her as my ‘mother’ when she is actually something different? I do not have a word for it...”

I reply, “*Shoresh*—I suggest that we use that. It is Hebrew for *root*. I guess that it is the best description, in several instances.”

She looks down for several moments. When she looks back at me, there is understanding in her eyes.

She tells me, “Yes, I have a father, but I have no mother—I have *Shores*. I can live with that. I must live with that. But I want to know who she was. Tell me.”

So I do as requested. I do it calmly, because time is not a problem now. Before the revelation, I feared and dreaded this moment, but now that the worst part is over, I want to savor these moments with her. I want to do it the right way.

I brew us a large pot of tea, the one that we use when there are visitors. And I grab a whole package of oat cookies along with a bar of dark chocolate and some dry fruits.

I assemble all things together on the small rustic wooden center table at our living room and call her to join me. I choose a playlist that, in retrospect, seems that was built exactly for this moment.

Acquaintance

He does it well. I can see that he's been preparing for this. He brings the cookies that I once liked but have for a while overgrown. He wants to make me comfortable.

I cannot keep hating him like I was doing just until now.

He starts from the very obvious: how they met each other. It does not interest me. I do not think that people are themselves when they are meeting someone new. I am not myself when meeting someone new.

I try not to interrupt, it is obvious that he is heading toward what I wish.

Now: her first personal wish.

Why did she want to go there?

Because it was the city of her family.

This does not make sense, Jews were not German citizens.

At some point, they had to become, Nazis, it was enforced law.

So everything was un-enforced decades later?

Ironies of history, but, yes...

And what happened there?

Not much, we visited the place where her family lived, and talked about what it meant.

Silence; tears; I don't know why, I do not know what to make of that, because she—*Shores*—had interests that I cannot understand, and that he cannot communicate.

How many more, of relatives, I mean?

Not many, there is a branch of the family, but it is not close.

Have you had contact with them?

No, never, they emigrated to the Americas.

Why not?

Hey, this was her family, I do not know everything.

Go on, tell me more.

Wait, don't you want to visit the location?

Do not distract me, we have only today for information, but forever for places.

He seems struck. I regret saying that, in retrospect, it sounds like a type of goodbye.

She's chosen your name.

What?

Yes, we talked often about that, which names to choose in case...

So you were... planning on having a child?

Yes, we even got genetically tested.

I have to think for a while.

So the whole talk about thalassemia...

... was already known. Yes, both me, and her, had it, and so do you.

This brings me a vertiginous feeling, I need to ask before it's too late.

So, it might be that even if she had not died, you would have opted to have a kid this way, as you yourself did alone?

He takes his time to answer.

“Yes.”

Acceptance

I leave her busy with her thoughts, as I imagined she would be after the conversation. I tell her that I am open to proceed further, but also that I will share with her some resources to orient her in the flood of information that the internet provides. It does not help that very little public facing information is in Germany, because the procedure is not allowed here and in the European Union.

But what really annoys me is the amount of information that is misleading or outright false, mostly from ads promoting clinics in other countries. It is inevitable that she will see the bad websites, sooner or later, but I would like her to read my selection first.

I do not share all at once; I give her at first enough reading for a part of today, so we can discuss after she finishes. As part of my curation, I share scientific and public facing articles on identity dysphoria disorders, which can vary from over-identification to consciously targeted negation of any similarity with the root.

She reads in her tablet, still in the kitchen, and does not care to sit on the couch or lie on her bed. I stay around in case she has any questions and pretend to read something in my device, but I actually just watch her. Of course she looks a lot like her mother, even if I tried to convince me otherwise, but not like I feared she could become when she

was young. The most striking similarities I notice are actually in her behavior, such as now, how deeply she can concentrate on something, and that flickering in the eyes that is the same.

It pains me to know that I will never be able to talk about that with her.

AFTER SHE FINISHES THE READINGS I HAVE LUNCH READY. We eat it in silence and I suggest that we go for a walk in our neighborhood. I do not tell why, but it is to anchor her through the familiar sights, to avoid dissociating from the life she had until now. To reassure her that she is still the same person.

It seems to work, I would like to think. Several times she stops and looks at sights that she saw thousands of times before, and I wonder if she is seeing something new or acknowledging the old. I do not ask and I fear the answer.

